Emmanuel Levinas

Basic Philosophical Writings

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EIGHT

God and Philosophy

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"God and Philosophy" is a far-ranging work that perhaps more than any other single essay serves as a summary of Levinas's mature thought.[1] Levinas sets out to show not only that the intelligibility of transcendence lies outside ontological structures but also that it bears an ethical sense or direction. The question of rational discourse about God which Levinas addresses in the first section is introduced in support of the claim that Western philosophy has been "a destruction of transcendence," albeit with a few exceptions.

Levinas had long allowed himself to be guided by two of those exceptions. The first was Plato's use of the phrase "beyond being" (*epekeina tes ousias*) to refer to the good; the second was Descartes's proof of the existence of God in the Third Meditation, which Levinas had explored in "Philosophy and the Idea of Infinity" in 1957 and used four years later to give structure to his first major work, *Totality and Infinity*. In "God and Philosophy," both models are appealed to, but more attention is given to the second. This is because Levinas finds in Descartes's account of a thought greater than I can contain a model of how transcendence breaks open the unity, immanence, and presence of the subject as ordinarily conceived by philosophy. Attaching to the Cartesian model a signification it does not bear in Descartes's presentation of it, Levinas claims that this transcendence has an ethical meaning. The argument is that the structure of transcendence is exemplified not by religious experience but by the ethical.

"God and Philosophy" opens with an implicit reference to Derrida's 1964 essay on Levinas, "Violence and Metaphysics." Derrida had quoted a Greek as saying, "If one has to philosophize, one has to philosophize; if one does not have to philosophize, one still has to philosophize (to say it and think it). One always has to philosophize" (see note 2). At the same time, Derrida quoted some remarks by Levinas which indicated his agreement with this formulation. Derrida's purpose was to establish that Levinas could not break free of the Western philosophical tradition, contrary to some of his more dramatic claims to that effect. At the close of "God and Philosophy" Levinas responded by contradicting Derrida directly: "not to philosophize would not be 'to philosophize still.'" This is important to Levinas because he insists that the ethical demand that the Other makes on me, so breaking up my subjectivity, comes from beyond philosophy. This is the way Levinas chooses to resist Derrida's description of the Greek *logos* as having the power to encompass whatever stands outside it.

The Priority of Philosophical Discourse and Ontology

1. "Not to philosophize is still to philosophize."[2] The philosophical discourse of the West claims the amplitude of an all-encompassing structure or of an ultimate comprehension. It compels every other discourse to justify itself before philosophy.

Rational theology accepts this vassalage. If, for the benefit of religion, it

reserves a domain from the authority of philosophy, one will know that this domain will have been recognized to be philosophically unverifiable.

2. The dignity of being the ultimate and royal discourse belongs to Western philosophy because of the strict coinciding of thought, in which philosophy resides, and the idea of reality in which this thought thinks. For thought, this coinciding means not having to think beyond what belongs to "being's move" ["*geste d'être*"], or at least not beyond what modifies a previous belongingness to "being's move," such as formal or ideal notions. For the being of reality, this coinciding means: to illuminate thought and the conceived by showing itself. To show oneself, to be illuminated, is just what having meaning is, what having intelligibility par excellence is, the intelligibility underlying every modification of meaning. Then we should have to understand the rationality of "being's move" not as some characteristic which would be attributed to it when a reason comes to know of it. That a thought comes to know of it is intelligibility. Rationality has to be understood as the incessant emergence of thought from the energy of "being's move" or its manifestation, and reason has to be understood out of this rationality. Meaningful thought, and thought about being, would be pleonasms and equivalent pleonasms, which, however, are justified by the vicissitudes and privations to which this identification of the thought of the meaningful and of being is de jure exposed.

3. Philosophical discourse therefore should be able to include God - of whom the Bible speaks - if this God does have a meaning. But as soon as he is conceived, this God is situated within "being's move." He is situated there as the *being* (*etant*) par excellence. If the intellectual understanding of the biblical God, theology, does not reach to the level of philosophical thought, this is not because it thinks of God as *a being* without first explicating the "being of this being," but because in thematizing God it brings God into the course of being. But, in the most unlikely way - that is, not analogous with an idea subject to *criteria* or subject to the demand that it show itself to be true or false - the God of the Bible signifies the beyond being, transcendence. It is not by chance that the history of Western philosophy has been a destruction of transcendence. Rational theology, fundamentally ontological, strives to take account of transcendence in the domain of being by expressing it with adverbs of height applied to the verb being; God is said to exist eminently or par excellence. But does the height, or the height above all height, that is thus expressed belong to ontology? And does not the modality which this adverb expresses, borrowed from the dimension of the sky over our heads, modify the verbal meaning of the verb to be to the point of excluding it from the thinkable as something inapprehendable, excluding it from the *esse* showing itself, that is, showing itself meaningfully in a theme?

4. One can also, to be sure, claim that the God of the Bible does not have meaning, that is, is not properly speaking thinkable. This would be the other term of the alternative. "The concept of God is not a problematical concept; it is not a concept at all," writes Mme. Delhomme in a recent book,[3] continuing a major tradition of philosophical rationalism which refuses to accept the transcendence of the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob among the concepts without which there would be no thought. What the Bible puts above all comprehension would have not yet reached the threshold of intelligibility!

The problem which is thus posed, and which will be ours, is whether the meaning that is equivalent to the *esse* of being, that is, the meaning which is meaning in philosophy, is not already a restriction of meaning. Is it not already a derivative or a drifting of meaning? Is not the meaning equivalent to essence - to being's move, to being qua being - first broached in presence, which is the time of the same? This supposition can be justified only through the possibility of going back from this allegedly conditioned meaning to a meaning which could no longer be put in terms of being or in terms of beings. We must ask if beyond the intelligibility and rationalism of identity, consciousness, the present, and being - beyond the intelligibility of immanence - the signifyingness, rationality, and rationalism of transcendence are not understood. Over and beyond being does not a meaning whose priority, translated into ontological language, would have to be called *antecedent* to being, show itself? It is not certain that in going beyond the terms and beings one necessarily relapses into speaking of opinion or faith. In fact, in staying or wanting to be outside of reason, faith and opinion speak the language of being. Nothing is less opposed to ontology than opinion and faith. To ask, as we are trying to do here, if God can be exposed in a rational discourse which would be neither ontology nor faith is implicitly to doubt the formal opposition, established by Yehouda Halevy and taken up by Pascal, between the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, invoked in faith without philosophy, and the god of philosophers.[4] It is to doubt that this opposition constitutes an alternative.

The Priority of Ontology and Immanence

5. We said that, for Western philosophy, meaning or intelligibility coincide with the manifestation of being, as if the very business of being led to clarity, in the form of intelligibility, and then became an intentional thematization in an experience. Pressing toward or waiting for it, all the potentialities of experience are derived from or susceptible to such thematization. Thematic exposition concludes the business of being or truth. But if being *is* manifestation, if the exertion of being amounts to this exhibition, the manifestation of being is only the manifestation of this "exertion," that is, the manifestation of manifestation, the truth of truth. Philosophy thus finds in manifestation its matter and its

form. In its attachment to being, to beings or the being of beings, it would thus remain a movement of knowledge and truth, an adventure of experience between the clear and the obscure. It is certain that this is the sense in which philosophy is the bearer of the spirituality of the West, where spirit is taken to be coextensive with knowing. But knowing - or thought, or experience - is not to be understood as a kind of reflection of exteriority in an inner forum. The notion of reflection, an optical metaphor taken from thematized beings and events, is not the proper trope for knowing. Knowing is only understood in its proper essence when one begins with consciousness, whose specificity is lost when it is defined with the concept of knowing, a concept which presupposes consciousness.

It is as a modality or modification of *insomnia* that consciousness is consciousness of . . . , a gathering into being or into presence, which, at a certain depth of vigilance where vigilance has to clothe itself with justice, is essential to insomnia.[3] Insomnia, wakefulness or vigilance, far from being definable as the simple negation of the natural phenomenon of sleep, belongs to the categorial, antecedent to all anthropological attention and stupor. Ever on the verge of awakening, sleep communicates with vigilance; while trying to escape, sleep stays tuned in, in an *obedience to the wakefulness* which threatens it and calls to it, which *demands*. The categorial proper to insomnia is not reducible to the tautological affirmation of the same, dialectical negation, or the ecstasy of thematizing intentionality. Here being awake is not equivalent to *watching over* . . . , where already the identical, rest, sleep, is sought after. It is in consciousness alone that the *watching*, already petrified, bends over toward a content which is identified and gathered into a presence, into a "move of being," and is absorbed in it. Insomnia as a category - or as a metacategory (but the *meta* becomes meaningful through it) - does not get inscribed in a table of categories from a determining activity exercised on the other as *given* by the unity of the Same (and all activity is but the identification and crystallization of the Same against the other, upon being affected by that other), in order to ensure to the other, consolidated into a being, the gravity of being. Insomnia - the wakefulness in awakening - is disturbed in the core of its formal or categorial *equality* by the *other*, which tears away at whatever forms a nucleus, a substance of the Same, identity, a rest, a presence, a sleep. Insomnia is disturbed by the other who breaks this rest, breaks it from this side of the *state* in which equality tends to establish itself. The irreducible categorial character of insomnia lies precisely in this: the other is in the Same and does not alienate the same but awakens it. Awakening is like a demand that no obedience is equal to, no obedience puts to sleep; it is a "more" in the "less." Or, to use an obsolete language, it is the spirituality of the soul, ceaselessly aroused from its state of soul, in which *wakefulness* itself already closes over upon itself or falls to sleep, resting within

the boundaries it has as a state. We find here the passivity of Inspiration, or the subjectivity of the subject aroused, sobered up, out of its being. There is a formalism in insomnia, a formalism more formal than that of any defining, delimiting, confining form, more formally formal than that of a form that closes into a presence and an *esse*, filling with content. Insomnia is wakefulness, but a wakefulness without intentionality - dis-interested. Its indeterminateness does not call for a form, is not a materiality. It is a form that does not *terminate* the drawing out of a form in it, and does not condense its own emptiness into a content. It is uncontained - Infinity.

6. Consciousness has already broken with this dis-interestedness. It is the identity of the Same, the presence of being, the presence of presence. We must think of consciousness beginning with the emphasis of presence.[6] Presence is only possible as a return of consciousness to itself, outside of sleep - and consciousness thus goes back to insomnia. That is so even though this return to itself, in the form of self-consciousness, is only a forgetting of the Other which awakens the Same from within, and even if the freedom of the same is still only a waking dream. Presence is only possible as an incessant taking up of presence again, an incessant re-presentation. The incessance of presence is a repetition, its being taken up again an apperception of representation. Re-presentation is not to be described as a taking up again (*re-prise*). Re-presentation is the very possibility of a return, the possibility of the *always*, or of the presence of the present. The unity of apperception, the "I think," which is discovered and acquired its role in re-presentation, is not a way to make presence purely subjective. The synthesis effected by the unity of the *I think* behind experience constitutes the act of presence, presence as an act, or presence in act. This encompassing movement is accomplished by the unity formed into a nucleus in the "I think," a synopsis which is a structure necessary for the actuality of the present. The "activity of the mind," the operative concept of transcendental idealism, is not based on an empirical experience of the deployment of intellectual energy. It is rather the extreme purity - to the point of tension - of the presence of presence, which is Aristotle's being in act, a presence of presence, an extreme tension breaking up *presence* into an "experience of a subject," where precisely presence returns upon itself and is filled up and fulfilled. The psychic nature of consciousness is this emphasis of being, this presence of presence, a presence outdoing itself, without loopholes, without hedging, any possible forgetting in the folds of what would be only implicit and could not be unfolded. The "incessance" is an explication without any possible shading off; it refers to an awakening that would be lucidity, but also to a watching over being, an attention to . . . , and not an exposedness to the other (and already a modification of the formalism without intentionality of insom-

nia). It is always true that because of consciousness nothing can be dissimulated in being. Consciousness is a light which illuminates the world from one end to the other; everything which goes off into the past is recalled or recovered by history. Reminiscence is the extreme consciousness which is also the universal presence and the universal ontology; whatever is able to fill the field of consciousness was, in its time, received or perceived, had an origin. Through consciousness the past is only a modification of the present. Nothing can happen and nothing could have happened without presenting itself, nothing could be smuggled by without being declared, without being shown, without being inspected as to its truth. Transcendental subjectivity is the figure of this presence; no signification precedes that which I give to myself.

Thus the process of the present unfolds through consciousness like a "held note" held in its *always*, in its identity of being the same, in the simultaneity of its moments. The process of the subjective does not come from the outside; the presence of the present involves consciousness. And philosophy, then, in search of the transcendental operations of the apperception of the *I think*, is not some unhealthy and accidental curiosity; it is representation, the reactualization of representation, that is, the emphasis of presence, being's remaining-the-same in the simultaneity of its presence, in its always, in its immanence. Philosophy is not merely the knowledge of immanence; it is immanence itself.[7]

7. Immanence and consciousness, as gathering up the manifestation of manifestation, are not disturbed by the phenomenological interpretation of affective states or of the voluntary psyche, which puts in the very heart of consciousness the emotion or the anxiety which upset its imperturbability - nor by that interpretation that starts from fear or trembling before the sacred, and understands them as primary lived states. It is not accidental that the axiological and practical strata in Husserl cover over a representational ground.

The axiological and the practical strata remain in experience - experiences of values, or experiences of the willed qua willed. The representational ground, which Husserl brings out in them, consists, moreover, less in some serenity of the theoretical intention than in the identification of the identical in the form of ideality, in the assembling, in the representation in the form of a presence, a lucidity which allows nothing to escape.[8] In short, it consists in immanence.

8. But let us take note of this: the interpretation of affectivity as a modification of representation, or as founded on a representation, succeeds in the measure that affectivity is taken at the level of a tendency, or concupiscence, as Pascal would say - at the level of an aspiration which can be satisfied in pleasure or, when unsatisfied, remains a pure lack which causes suffering. Beneath such an affectivity is found the ontological activity of consciousness - wholly investment and comprehension, that is, presence and representation (of which

the specifically theoretical thematization is but a modality). This does not exclude the possibility that, in another direction besides that of a tendency going to its term, there break out an affectivity which breaks with the form and the purpose of consciousness, and leaves immanence, is a transcendence. We are going to try to speak of this "elsewhere."

9. A religious thought which appeals to religious experiences allegedly independent of philosophy already, inasmuch as it is founded on experience, refers to the "I think," and is wholly connected on to philosophy. The "narration" of religious experience does not shake philosophy and cannot break with presence and immanence, of which philosophy is the emphatic completion. It is possible that the word God has come to philosophy out of religious discourse. But even if philosophy refuses this discourse, it understands it as a language made of propositions bearing on a theme, that is, as having a meaning which refers to a disclosure, a manifestation of presence. The bearers of religious experience do not conceive of any other signification of meaning. Religious "revelation" is therewith already assimilated to philosophical disclosure; even dialectical theology maintains this assimilation. That a discourse can speak otherwise than to say what has been seen or heard on the outside, or previously experienced, remains unsuspected. From the start then a religious being interprets what he lived through as an experience. In spite of himself he already interprets God, of whom he claims to have an experience, in terms of being, presence and immanence.

Then the first question has to be: can discourse signify otherwise than by signifying a theme? Does God signify as the theme of the religious discourse which names God - or as the discourse which, at least to begin with, does not name him, but says him with another form of address than denomination or evocation?

The Idea of the Infinite

10. The thematization of God in religious experience has already dodged or missed the inordinate intrigue that breaks up the unity of the "I think."[9]

In his meditation on the idea of God, Descartes, with an unequaled rigor, has sketched out the extraordinary course of a thought that proceeds on to the breakup of the *I think*. Although he conceives of God as a being, he conceives of him as an eminent being or being that *is* eminently. Before this rapprochement between the idea of God and the idea of being, we do indeed have to ask whether the adjective *eminent* and the adverb *eminently* do not refer to the elevation of the sky above our heads, and whether they do not go beyond ontology. Be that as it may, interpreting the immeasurability of God as a superlative case of existing, Descartes maintains a substantialist language. But

for us this is not what is unsurpassable in his mediation. It is not the proofs of God's existence that matter to us here but the breakup of consciousness, which is not a repression into the unconscious but a sobering up or an awakening, jolting the "dogmatic slumber" which sleeps at the bottom of every consciousness resting on its object. The idea of God, the *cogitatum* of a *cogitatio* which *to begin with* contains that *cogitatio*, signifies the noncontained par excellence. Is not that the very absolution of the absolute? It overflows every capacity; the "objective reality" of the *cogitatum* breaks up the "formal reality" of the *cogitatio*. This perhaps overturns, in advance, the universal validity and primordial character of intentionality. We will say that the idea of God breaks up the thought, which is an investment, a synopsis, and a synthesis and can only enclose in a presence, re-present, reduce to presence or let be.

Malebranche knew how to gauge the import of this event; there is no idea of God, or God is his own idea.[10] We are outside the order in which one passes from an idea to a being. The idea of God is God in me, but God already breaking up the consciousness which aims at ideas, and unlike any content. This difference is certainly not an emergence, which would be to imply that an inclusion of God in consciousness had been possible, nor some sort of escaping the realm of consciousness, which is to imply that there could have been *comprehension*. And yet there is an idea of God, or God is in us, as though the being-not-includable were also an ex-ceptional relationship with me, as though the difference between the Infinite and what ought to include and comprehend it were a nonindifference of the Infinite to this impossible inclusion, a non-indifference of the Infinite to thought. There is a putting of the Infinite into thought, but this is wholly different from what is structured as a comprehension of a *cogitatum* by a *cogitatio*. This putting is an unequaled passivity, because it is unassumable. (It is perhaps in this passivity - beyond all passivity - that we should recognize awakening.) Or, conversely, it is as though the negation of the finite included in In-finity did not signify any sort of negation resulting from the formal structure of negative judgment but rather signified the *idea of the Infinite*, that is, the Infinite in me. Or, more exactly, it is as though the psyche in subjectivity were equivalent to the negation of the finite by the Infinite, as though - without wanting to play on words - the *in* of the Infinite were to signify both the *non* and the *within*.[11]

11. The actuality of the *cogito* is thus interrupted by the unincludable, not thought but undergone in the form of the idea of the Infinite, bearing in a second moment of consciousness what in a first moment claimed to bear it. After the certainty of the *cogito*, present to itself in the Second Meditation, after the "halt" which the last lines of this meditation mark, the Third Meditation announces that "in some way I have in me the notion of the infinite earlier than

the finite - to wit, the notion of God before that of myself." The idea of the Infinite, *Infinity in me*, can only be a passivity of consciousness. Is it still consciousness? There is here a passivity which cannot be likened to receptivity. Receptivity is a collecting that takes place in a welcome, an assuming that takes place under the force of the blow received. The breakup of the actuality of thought in the "idea of God" is a passivity more passive still than any passivity, like the passivity of a trauma through which the idea of God would have been put into us. An "idea put into us" - does this stylistic turn suit the subjectivity of the cogito? Does it suit consciousness and its way of holding a content, which is to always leave some traces of its grasp on it? Does not consciousness, in its present, get its origin and its contents from itself? Can an idea be put into a thought and abjure its letters patent of Socratic nobility, its immanent birth in reminiscence, that is, its origin in the very presence of the thought that thinks it, or in the recuperation of this thought by memory? But in the idea of the Infinite there is described a passivity more passive still than any passivity befitting consciousness: there is the surprise or susception of the unassumable, more open still than any openness - wakefulness - but suggesting the passivity of someone created.[11] The putting into us of an unincludable idea overturns that presence to self which consciousness is, forcing its way through the barrier and checkpoint, eluding the obligation to accept or adopt all that enters from the outside. It is then an idea signifying with a signifyingness prior to presence, to all presence, prior to every origin in consciousness and thus an-archical, accessible in its trace. It signifies with a signifyingness from the first older than its exhibition, not exhausting itself in exhibiting itself, not drawing its meaning from its manifestation, and thus breaking with the coinciding of being with appearance in which, for Western philosophy, meaning or rationality lie, breaking with synopsis. It is more ancient than the rememberable thought which representation retains in its presence. What can this signification more ancient than exhibition mean? Or, more exactly, what can the antiquity of a signification mean? In exhibition, can it enter into another time than that of the historical present, which already annuls the past and its dia-chrony by re-presenting it? What can this antiquity mean if not the trauma of awakening - as though the idea of the Infinite, the Infinite in us, awakened a consciousness which is not awakened enough? As though the idea of the Infinite in us were a demand, and a signification in the sense that an order is signified in a demand.

Divine Comedy

12. We have already said that it is not in the negation of the finite by the Infinite, understood in its abstraction and logical formalism, that the idea of the Infinite, or the Infinite in thought, is to be interpreted. On the contrary: the idea of the Infinite, or the Infinite in thought, is the proper and irreducible figure for the

negation of the finite. The *in* of infinity is not a *not* like any other; its negation is the subjectivity of the subject, which is behind intentionality. The difference between the Infinite and finite is behind intentionality. The difference between the Infinite and the finite is a nonindifference of the Infinite to the finite, and is the secret of subjectivity. The figure of the Infinite-put-in-me, and, according to Descartes, contemporaneous with my creation,[13] would mean that the not-being-able-to-comprehend-the-Infinite-by-thought is somehow a positive relationship with this thought - but with this thought as passive, as a *cogitatio* as though dumbfounded and no longer, or not yet, commanding the *cogitatum*, not yet hastening toward adequation between the term of the spontaneous teleology of consciousness and this term given in being. Such an adequation is the destiny of the essential teleology of consciousness, which proceeds to its intentional term, and conjures up the presence of re-presentation. Better yet, the not-being-able-to-comprehend-the-Infinite-by-thought would signify the condition - or the unconditionality - of thought, as though to speak of the noncomprehension of the Infinite by the finite did not amount to simply saying that the Infinite is not finite, and as though the affirmation of the difference between the Infinite and the finite had to remain a verbal abstraction, without consideration of the fact that through the noncomprehension of the Infinite by thought, thought is posited as thought,[14] as a posited subjectivity, that is, is posited as self-positing. The Infinite has nothing to add on to itself so as to affect subjectivity; its very in-finity, its difference from the finite, is already its nonindifference to the finite. This amounts to a *cogitatio not comprehending* the *cogitatum* which affects it utterly. The Infinite affects thought by devastating it and at the same time calls upon it; in a "putting it back in its place" it puts thought in place. It awakens it. The awakening of thought is not a welcoming of the Infinite, is not a recollecting, not an assuming, which are necessary and sufficient for *experience*. The idea of the Infinite puts these in question. The idea of the Infinite is not even taken up as love, which is awakened when the arrow strikes, but then the subject stunned by the trauma finds himself forthwith in the immanence of a state of soul. The Infinite signifies precisely prior to its manifestation; here the meaning is not reducible to manifestation, the representation of presence, or teleology. Here meaning is not measured by the possibility or impossibility of the truth of being, even if this antecedent signification should, in one way or another - and if only through its trace - show itself in the enigmas involved in saying.

13. What then is the plot of meaning, other than that of re-presentation and of empirical experience, which is hatched in the idea of the Infinite - in the monstrosity of the Infinite *put* in me - an idea which in its passivity over and beyond all receptivity is no longer an idea? What is the meaning of the trauma

of awakening, in which the Infinite can neither be posited as a correlate of the subject, nor enter into a structure with it, nor become its contemporary in a co-presence - but in which it is transcended? How is transcendence as a relationship thinkable if it must exclude the ultimate and the most formal co-presence which a relationship guarantees to its terms?

The *in* of the Infinite designates the depth of the affecting by which subjectivity is affected through this "putting" of the Infinite into it, without prehension or comprehension. It designates the depth of an undergoing that no capacity comprehends, that no foundation any longer supports, where every process of investing fails and where the screws that fix the stern of inwardness burst. This putting in without a corresponding recollecting devastates its site like a devouring fire, catastrophying its site, in the etymological sense of the word.[15] It is a dazzling, where the eye takes more than it can hold, an igniting of the skin which touches and does not touch what is beyond the graspable, and burns. It is a passivity or a passion in which desire can be recognized, in which the "*more* in the *less*" awakens by its most ardent, noblest and most ancient flame a thought given over to thinking more than it thinks.[16] But this desire is of another order than the desires involved in hedonist or eudaemonist affectivity and activity, where the desirable is invested, reached, and identified as an object of need, and where the immanence of representation and of the exterior world is restored. The negativity of the *in* of the Infinite - otherwise than being, divine comedy - hollows out a desire which cannot be filled, nourishes itself with its very augmentation, and is exalted as a desire, withdraws from its satisfaction in the measure that it approaches the desirable. It is a desire that is beyond satisfaction, and, unlike a need, does not identify a term or an end. This endless desire for what is beyond being is dis-inter*estedness*, transcendence - desire for the Good.

But if the Infinite in me means a desire for the Infinite, is one certain of the transcendence which *passes* there? Does not desire restore the contemporaneousness of desiring and the desirable? Or, in other words, does not the desiring being derive from the desirable a complacency in desiring, as though it had already grasped it by its intention? Is not the disinter*estedness* of the desire for the Infinite an inter*estedness*? We have spoken of a desire for the Good beyond being, a transcendence, without giving our attention to the way interestedness is excluded from the desire for the Infinite, and without showing how the transcendent Infinite deserves the name Good, when its very transcendence can, it seems, only mean indifference.

14. Love is possible only through the idea of the Infinite - through the Infinite put in me, through the "more" which devastates and awakens the "less," turning away from teleology, destroying the moment and the happiness of the end. Plato forces out of Aristophanes an admission which, coming from

the lips of the master of comedy, is striking indeed: "These are the people who pass their whole lives together; yet they could not explain what they desire of one another."[17] Hephaestus will say that they want to become "one instead of two,"[18] and he thus assigns an end to love and reduces it to a nostalgia for what was in the past. But why can the lovers themselves not say what they ask from one another beyond pleasure? Diotima will put love's intention beyond this unity but will find love to be indigent, needy, and subject to vulgarity. The celestial and the vulgar Venus are sisters. Love is complacent in waiting for the lovable, that is, it enjoys the lovable through the representation which fills up the waiting. Perhaps pornography is that, arising in all eroticism, as eroticism arises in all love. Losing in this enjoyment the inordinateness of desire, love is concupiscence, in Pascal's sense of the term,[19] an assuming and an investing by the *I*. The *I think* reconstitutes presence and being, interestedness and immanence, in love.

Is a transcendence of the Desirable beyond the interestedness and eroticism in which the Beloved abides possible? Affected by the Infinite, Desire cannot proceed to an end which it would be equal to; in Desire the approach distances, and enjoyment is but the increase of hunger. Transcendence or the disinterestedness of Desire "passes" in this reversal of terms. How? And in the transcendence of the Infinite what dictates to us the word Good? For disinterestedness to be possible in the Desire for the Infinite, for the desire beyond being, or transcendence, not to be an absorption in immanence, which would thus make its return, it is necessary that the Desirable or God remain separated in the Desire; as desirable it is near but different: Holy. This can only be if the Desirable orders me to what is the nondesirable, the undesirable par excellence - the other (*autrui*). The reference to the other (*autrui*) is an awakening, an awakening to proximity, and this is a responsibility for the neighbor, to the point of substituting for him. Elsewhere[20] we have shown that substitution for the other (*autrui*) lies in the heart of responsibility, an undoing of the nucleus of the transcendental subject, the transcendence of goodness, the nobility of a pure *supporting*, an ipseity of pure election. Such is Love without Eros. Transcendence is ethics, and subjectivity, which is not, in the last analysis, the "I think" (which it is at first) or the unity of "transcendental apperception," is, as a responsibility for the Other (*Autrui*), a subjection to the other (*autrui*). The I is a passivity more passive still than any passivity because it is from the first in the accusative - oneself [*soi*] - and never was in the nominative; it is under the accusation of the other (*autrui*), even though it be faultless. It is a hostage for the other (*autrui*), obeying a command before having heard it, faithful to a commitment that it never made, to a past that has never been present. This wakefulness or openness to oneself is completely exposed, and sobered up from the ecstasy of intentionality. We have designated this way for the Infinite, or for God, to refer, from the

heart of its very desirability, to the nondesirable proximity of others, by the term "illeity"; it is the extraordinary reversal of the desirability of the Desirable, the supreme desirability, calling to itself the rectilinear straightforwardness of Desire. Through this reversal the Desirable escapes desire. The goodness of the Good - the Good which never sleeps or nods - inclines the movement it calls forth, to turn it from the Good and orient it toward the other (*autrui*), and only thus toward the Good. Here is an obliqueness that goes higher than straightforwardness. The desirable is intangible and separates itself from the relationship with desire which it calls for; through this separation or holiness it remains a third person, the *he* in the depth of the You. He is Good in just this eminent sense; He does not fill me up with goods but compels me to goodness, which is better than goods received.[21]

To be good is a deficit, waste and foolishness in a being; to be good is excellence and elevation beyond being. Ethics is not a moment of being; it is otherwise and better than being, the very possibility of the beyond.[22] In this ethical reversal, in this reference of the Desirable to the Nondesirable, in this strange mission that orders the approach to the other (*autrui*), God is drawn out of objectivity, presence, and being. He is neither an object nor an interlocutor. His absolute remoteness, his transcendence, turns into my responsibility - nonerotic par excellence - for the other (*autrui*). And this analysis implies that God is not simply the "first other (*autrui*)," the other (*autrui*) par excellence, or the "absolutely other (*autrui*)," but other than the other (*autre qu'autrui*), other otherwise, other with an alterity prior to the alterity of the other (*autrui*), prior to the ethical bond with the other (*autrui*) and different from every neighbor, transcendent to the point of absence, to the point of a possible confusion with the stirring of the *there is*.[23] In this confusion the substitution for the neighbor gains in dis-inter*estedness*, that is, in nobility, and the transcendence of the Infinite arises in glory. Such transcendence is true with a dia-chronic truth and without any synthesis, higher than the truths that are without enigma.[24] For this formula "transcendence to the point of absence" not to mean the simple explicitation of an ex-ceptional word, this word itself has to be put back into the significance of the whole plot of the ethical or back into the divine comedy without which it could not have arisen. That comedy is enacted equivocally between temple and theater, but in it the laughter sticks to one's throat when the neighbor approaches - that is, when his face, or his forsakenness, draws near.

Phenomenology and Transcendence

15. The exposition of the ethical signification of transcendence and of the Infinite beyond being can be worked out beginning with the proximity of the neighbor and my responsibility for the other (*autrui*).

Until then a passive subjectivity might seem something constructed and abstract. The receptivity of finite knowledge is an assembling of a dispersed given in the simultaneity of presence, in immanence. The passivity "more passive still than any passivity" consisted in undergoing - or more exactly in having already undergone, in a nonrepresentable past which was never present - a trauma that could not be assumed; it consisted in being struck by the "*in*" of infinity which devastates presence and awakens subjectivity to the proximity of the other (*autrui*). The noncontained, which breaks the container or the forms of consciousness, thus *transcends* the essence or the "move" of knowable being which carries on its being in presence; it transcends the inter*estedness* and simultaneity of a representable or historically reconstitutable temporality; it transcends immanence.

This trauma, which cannot be assumed, inflicted by the Infinite on presence, or this affecting of presence by the Infinite - this affectivity - takes shape as a subjection to the neighbor. It is thought thinking more than it thinks, desire, the reference to the neighbor, the responsibility for another.

This abstraction is nevertheless familiar to us in the empirical event of obligation to the other (*autrui*), as the impossibility of indifference - impossible without fail - before the misfortunes and faults of a neighbor, the unexceptionable responsibility for him. It is impossible to fix limits or measure the extreme urgency of this responsibility. Upon reflection it is something completely astonishing, a responsibility that even extends to the obligation to answer for another's freedom, to be responsible for his responsibility, whereas the freedom which would demand an eventual commitment or even the assuming of an imposed necessity cannot find a present that includes the possibilities which belong to the other (*autrui*). The other's (*autrui*) freedom can neither constitute a structure along with my freedom, nor enter into a synthesis with it. Responsibility for the neighbor is precisely what goes beyond the legal and obliges beyond contracts; it comes to me from what is prior to my freedom, from a nonpresent, an immemorial. A difference gapes open between me and the other that no unity of transcendental apperception can undo. My responsibility for the other (*autrui*) is precisely the nonindifference of this difference - the proximity of the other. An absolutely extra-ordinary relation, it does not reestablish the order of representation in which every past returns. The proximity of a neighbor remains a dia-chronic break, a resistance of time to the synthesis of simultaneity.

The biological human brotherhood - conceived with the sober coldness of Cain - is not a sufficient reason for me to be responsible for a separated being. The sober coldness of Cain consists in conceiving responsibility as proceeding from freedom or in terms of a contract. But responsibility for the other comes from what is prior to my freedom. It does not come from the time made up of

presences, nor presences that have sunk into the past and are representable, the time of beginnings or assumings. It does not allow me to constitute myself into an *I think*, substantial like a stone, or, like a heart of stone, existing in and for oneself. It ends up in substitution for the other, in the condition - or the unconditionality - of being a hostage. Such responsibility does not give one time, a present for recollection or coming back to oneself; it makes one always late. Before the neighbor I am summoned and do not just appear; from the first I am answering to an assignation. Already the stony core of my substance is dislodged. But the responsibility to which I am exposed in such a passivity does not apprehend me as an interchangeable thing, for here no one can be substituted for me; in calling upon me as someone accused who cannot reject the accusation, it obliges me as someone unreplaceable and unique, someone chosen. Inasmuch as it calls upon my responsibility it forbids me any replacement. Unreplaceable in responsibility, I cannot, without defaulting, incurring fault, or being caught up in some complex, escape the face of a neighbor; here I am pledged to the other without being able to take back my pledge.[25] I cannot evade the face of the other (*autrui*), naked and without resources. The nakedness of someone forsaken shows in the cracks in the mask of the personage, or in his wrinkled skin;[26] his being "without resources" has to be heard like cries not voiced or thematized, already addressed to God. There the resonance of silence - *Geläut der Stille*[27] - certainly sounds. We here have come upon an imbroglio that has to be taken seriously: a relationship to . . . that is not represented, without intentionality, not repressed; it is the latent birth of religion in the other (*autrui*), prior to emotions or voices, prior to "religious experience," which speaks of revelation in terms of the disclosure of being, when it is a question of an unwonted access, in the heart of my responsibility, to an unwonted disturbance of being. Even if one says right away, "It was nothing." "It was nothing" - it was not being, but otherwise than being. My responsibility in spite of myself - which is the way the other's (*autrui*) charge falls upon me or disturbs me, that is, is close to me - is the hearing or understanding of this cry. It is awakening. The proximity of a neighbor is my responsibility for him; to approach is to be one's brother's keeper; to be one's brother's keeper is to be his hostage. Immediacy is this. Responsibility does not come from fraternity, but fraternity denotes responsibility for the other (*autrui*), antecedent to my freedom.

16. To posit subjectivity in this responsibility is to catch sight of a passivity in it, is never passive enough, that of being consumed for the other (*autrui*). The very light of subjectivity shines and illuminates out of this ardor, although the ashes of this consummation are not able to fashion the kernel of a being existing in and for itself, and the I does not oppose to the other any form that protects itself or provides it with a measure. Such is the consuming of a holocaust. "I am

dust and ashes," says Abraham in interceding for Sodom.[28] "What are we?" says Moses more humbly still.[29]

What is the meaning of this assignation in which the nucleus of the subject is uprooted, undone, and does not receive any form capable of assuming this? What do these atomic metaphors mean, if not an I torn from the concept of the ego and from the content of obligations for which the concept rigorously supplies measure and rule, and thus left to an unmeasured responsibility, because it increases in the measure - or in the immeasurableness - that a response is made, increasing gloriously. This is the I that is not designated but which says "here I am." "Each of us is guilty before everyone, for everyone and for every thing, and I more than the others," writes Dostoyevsky in *The Brothers Karamazov*.[30] The I which says I is not that which singularizes or individuates a concept or a genus. It is I, unique in its genus, who speaks to you in the first person. That is, unless one could maintain that it is in the individuation of the genus or the concept of the ego that I myself awaken and expose myself to others, that is, begin to speak. This exposedness is not like self-consciousness, the recurrence of the subject to himself, confirming the ego by itself. The recurrence in awakening is something one can describe as a shudder of incarnation through which *giving* takes on meaning, as the primordial dative of the *for another*, in which a subject becomes a heart, a sensibility, and hands which give. But it is thus a position already deposed of its kingdom of identity and substance, already in debt, "for the other" to the point of substitution for the other, altering the immanence of the subject in the depths of its identity. This subject unreplaceable for the responsibility assigned to him finds in that very fact a new identity. But in extracting me from the concept of the ego, the fission of the subject is a growth of obligation in proportion as obedience grows, the augmentation of guilt that comes with the augmentation of holiness, the increase of distance proportionate to the approach. Here there is no rest for the self sheltered in its form, in its ego-concept! There are no "conditions," not even those of servitude. There is an incessant solicitude for solicitude, the extreme of passivity in responsibility for the responsibility of the other. Thus proximity is never close enough; as responsible, I am never finished with emptying myself of myself. There is infinite increase in this exhausting of oneself, in which the subject is not simply an awareness of this expenditure, but is its locus and event and, so to speak its goodness. The *glory of a long desire*! The subject as a hostage has been neither the experience nor the proof of the Infinite, but a witness borne of the Infinite, a modality of this glory, a testimony that no disclosure has preceded.

17. This growing surplus of the infinite that we have ventured to call *glory* is not an abstract quintessence. It has a signification in the response to the

summons which comes to me from the face of a neighbor, and which could not be evaded; it is the hyperbolic demand which at once exceeds that response. This comes as a surprise for the respondent himself by which, ousted from his inwardness as an ego and a "being with two sides," he is awakened, that is, exposed to the other without restraint or reserve. The passivity of such an exposure to the other (*autrui*) is not exhausted in some sort of being open to the other's (*autrui*) look or objectifying judgment. The openness of the ego exposed to the other is the breakup or turning inside out of inwardness. Sincerity is the name of this extraversion.[11] But what else can this inversion or extra-version mean but a responsibility for others such that I keep nothing for myself? A responsibility such that everything in me is debt and donation and such that my being-there is the ultimate *being-there*[12] where the creditors find the debtor? It is a responsibility such that my position as a subject in its *as for itself* is already my substitution or expiation for others. Responsibility for the other (*autrui*) - for his distress and his freedom - does not derive from any commitment, project or antecedent disclosure, in which the subject would be posited for itself before being-in-debt. Here passivity is extreme in the measure (or in-ordinate-ness) that the devotion for the other is not shut up in itself like a state of soul, but is itself from the start given over to the other.

This excess is *saying*. Sincerity is not an attribute which eventually receives the saying; it is by saying that sincerity - exposedness without reserve - is first possible. Saying makes signs to the other (*autrui*), but in this sign signifies the very giving of signs. Saying opens me to the other (*autrui*) before saying what is said, before the said uttered in this sincerity forms a screen between me and the other. A saying without words, but not with empty hands. If silence speaks, it is not through some inward mystery or some sort of ecstasy of intentionality, but through the hyperbolic passivity of giving, which is prior to all willing and thematization. Saying bears witness to the other (*autrui*) of the Infinite which rends me, which in the Saying awakens me.

Language understood in this way loses its superfluous and strange function of doubling up thought and being. Saying as testimony precedes all the said. Saying, before setting forth a said, is already the testimony of this responsibility - and even the saying of a said, as an approach to the other, is a responsibility for him. Saying is therefore a way of signifying prior to all experience. A pure testimony, it is a martyr's truth which does not depend on any disclosure or any "religious" experience; it is an obedience that precedes the hearing of any order. A pure testimony, it does not testify to a prior experience, but to the Infinite which is not accessible to the unity of apperception, nonappearing and disproportionate to the present. Saying could neither include nor comprehend the Infinite; the Infinite concerns and closes in on me while speaking through my mouth. And the only pure testimony is that of the Infinite. This is not a

psychological wonder, but the modality in which the Infinite *comes to pass*, signifying through him to whom it signifies, understood inasmuch as, before any commitment, I answer for the other (*autrui*).

Like someone put under leaden skies that suppress every shadowy corner in me, every residue of mystery, every mental reservation, every "as for me . . . ," hardening or relaxing of the plot of things by which escape would be possible, I am a testimony, or a trace, or the glory of the Infinite, breaking the bad silence which harbors Gyges's secrecy.[33] There is extra-verting of subject's inwardness; the subject becomes visible before becoming a seer! The Infinite is not "in front of" me; I express it, but precisely by giving a sign of the giving of signs, of the "for-the-other" in which I am dis-interested: here I am (*me voici*)! The accusative here is remarkable: here I am, under your eyes, at your service, your obedient servant.[34] In the name of God. But this is without thematization; the sentence in which God gets mixed in with words is not "I believe in God." The religious discourse that precedes all religious discourse is not dialogue. It is the "here I am" said to a neighbor to whom I am given over, by which I announce peace, that is, my responsibility for the other. "Creating language on their lips. . . . Peace, peace to him who is far and to him who is near, says the Eternal."[35]

Prophetic Signification

18. In the description which has been elaborated up to now there has been no question of the transcendental condition for some sort of ethical experience. Ethics as substitution for the other (*autrui*), giving without reserve, breaks up the unity of transcendental apperception, that condition for all being and all experience. Dis-inter*estedness* in the radical sense of the term, ethics designates the improbable field where the Infinite is in relationship with the finite without contradicting itself by this relationship, where on the contrary it alone *comes to pass* as Infinity and as awakening. The Infinite transcends itself in the finite, it *passes* the finite, in that it directs the neighbor to me without exposing itself to me. This order steals into me like a thief, despite the outstretched nets of consciousness, a trauma which surprises me absolutely, always already *passed* in a past which was never present and remains unrepresentable.

One can call this intrigue of infinity, where I make myself the author of what I understand, *inspiration*. It constitutes, prior to the unity of apperception, the very psyche in the soul. In this inspiration, or prophesying, I am the go-between for what I set forth. "God has spoken that you shall not prophesy," says Amos,[36] comparing the prophetic reaction to the passivity of the fear which takes hold of him who hears the roaring of wild beasts. Prophesying is pure testimony, pure because prior to all disclosure; it is subjection to an order before understanding the order. In the recoverable time of reminiscence, this anachronism is no less paradoxical than a prediction of the future. It is in prophesying that the Infinite

passes - and awakens. As a transcendence, refusing objectification and dialogue, it signifies in an ethical way. It *signifies* in the sense in which one says *to mean an order*, it *orders*.

19. In sketching out, behind philosophy where transcendence is always reduced, the outlines of prophetic testimony, we have not entered into the shifting sands of religious experience. To say that subjectivity is the temple or the theater of transcendence and that the understanding of transcendence takes on an ethical meaning does indeed not contradict the idea of the Good beyond being. This idea guarantees the philosophical dignity of an undertaking in which the signifyingness of meaning is separated from the manifestation or the presence of being. But one can only wonder if Western philosophy has been faithful to this Platonism. It discovered intelligibility in terms in conjunction, posited by relation with one another, signifying one another; for Western philosophy, being, thematized in its presence, is illuminated in this way. The clarity of the visible signifies. The appropriate trope for the signifyingness of signification is: the-one-for-the-other. But signifyingness becomes visibility, immanence, and ontology, inasmuch as the terms unite into a whole, and even their history is systematized, so as to be clarified.

On the pages of this study, transcendence as the ethical structure, the-one-for-the-other, has been formulated in terms of signifyingness and intelligibility.[37] The trope of intelligibility takes form in the ethical one-for-the-other, a signifyingness prior to that which terms in conjunction in a system acquire. But does this signifyingness more ancient than all patterns really *take form*? We have shown elsewhere the latent birth of systems and philosophy out of this august intelligibility; we shall not return to that here.[38]

The intelligibility of transcendence is not something ontological. The transcendence of God cannot be stated or conceived in terms of being, the element of philosophy, behind which philosophy sees only night. But the break between philosophical intelligibility and the beyond being, or the contradiction there would be in com-prehending infinity, does not exclude God from signifyingness, which, if it is not ontological, does not simply amount to thoughts bearing on being in decline, to views lacking necessity and wordplays.

In our times - is this its very modernity? - a presumption of being an ideology weighs on philosophy. This presumption cannot claim to be a part of philosophy, where the critical spirit cannot content itself with suspicions, but owes it to itself that it bring forth proofs. This presumption, which is irrecusable, draws its force from elsewhere. It begins in a cry of ethical revolt, bearing witness to responsibility; it begins in prophecy. Philosophy does not become suspect at just any moment in the spiritual history of the West. To recognize with philosophy - or to recognize philosophically - that the real is rational and that

the rational is alone real, and not to be able to smother or cover over the cry of those who, the morrow after this recognition, mean to transform the world, is already to move in a domain of meaning which the inclusion cannot comprehend and among reasons that "reason" does not know, and which have not begun in philosophy.[39] A meaning thus seems to bear witness to a beyond which would not be the no-man's-land of non-sense where opinions accumulate. *Not to philosophize would not be "to philosophize still,"* nor to succumb to opinions. There is meaning testified to in interjections and outcries, before being disclosed in propositions, a meaning that signifies as a command, like an order that one signifies. Its manifestation in a theme already devolves from its signifying as ordering; ethical signification signifies not *for* a consciousness which thematizes but *to* a subjectivity, wholly an obedience, obeying with an obedience that precedes understanding. Here is a passivity still more passive than that of receptivity in knowing, the receptivity that assumes what affects it. In this signification the ethical moment is not founded on any preliminary structure of theoretical thought, on language or on any particular language. Language then has over signification only the hold a form has, clothing matter. This recalls the distinction between form and signification, which shows itself in that distinction and through its references to a linguistic system. The distinction holds even if this *said* has to be *unsaid* - and it will have to so as to lose its linguistic alternation. The signification will indeed have to be reduced and lose the "stains" to which it owed its exposition to the light or its sojourn in shadow. An alternating rhythm of the said and the unsaid, and the unsaid being unsaid in its turn, will have to be substituted for the unity of discourse. There is here a breakup of the omnipotence of the logos, that of system and simultaneity. The logos breaks up into a signifier and a signified which is not *only* a signifier. This negates the attempt to amalgamate signifier and signified and to drive transcendence from its first or last refuge, in consigning all thought to language as a system of signs. Such an attempt was elaborated in the shadow of a philosophy for which meaning is equivalent to the manifestation of being, and manifestation equivalent to being's *esse*.

Transcendence as signification and signification as the signification of an order given to subjectivity before any statement are the pure one-for-the-other. Poor ethical subjectivity deprived of freedom! - unless this would be the trauma of a fission of the self that occurs in an adventure undergone with God or through God. But in fact this ambiguity also is necessary to transcendence. Transcendence owes it to itself to interrupt its own demonstration and monstration, its phenomenality. It requires the blinking and dia-chrony of enigma, which is not simply a precarious certainty but breaks up the unity of transcendental apperception, in which immanence always triumphs over transcendence.